

Island, from August 27–29.

Accompanying her into this tennis pantheon will be none other than 20-time Major champion Roger Federer.

In this interview, Carillo, 68, talks about her roots, her trailblazing career as the first woman to regularly broadcast tennis, the most memorable and transformative people she covered, and the burning controversies she analysed. With insights of an elder stateswoman, she also assesses today's game and predicts what the future holds for this intriguing, ever-evolving sport.

You fell in love with tennis as a talented teenager at the perfect time and place. Tell me about that exciting era and your tennis pals.

I was lucky in so many ways. I swam on the Douglaston Club swim team but kept getting swimmer's ear. One day, I climbed out of the pool and saw Court One down below me. The Sirna family took the court, wearing classic Fred Perry clothing that looked elegant and very warm to a shivering nine-year-old. I watched them play, then began watching the club pro, Dan Dwyer, give lessons. He was a gem. I picked up balls as he taught, listening to him the whole time. He liked me for it.

At the same time, John McEnroe, who lived up the block from the club, started playing, and Dan gave him plenty of time, too. John started entering tournaments, so I did, too. He started attending the Port Washington Tennis Academy, I followed. It was a fantastic hotbed of tennis. Harry Hopman was the head of Port, and all I wanted was for the great Davis Cup Captain from Australia to notice me, spend time on my court, and see how much I wanted to get better. My mom drove me to the academy every day, and I stayed for hours every day. Vitas Gerulaitis was there at the same time, and his younger sister Ruta became my best friend. When Vitas played at Wimbledon for the first time, I couldn't believe I knew



someone who played there.

When Mr. Hopman moved down to Florida to begin his own academy, I was a senior in high school. He asked me if I wanted to go with him, to teach and train, and without asking my parents' permission, I said yes. They let me. My mom was not thrilled, but they didn't stand in the way. I loved it there. Tennis was booming (in the 1970s), and world-class players came to train with Mr. Hopman. I worked for him for a few years and then again in between knee operations. He was everything to me.

I turned pro at a time when tennis was so damn popular and exciting. I was in locker rooms with Billie Jean King, Rosie Casals, Virginia Wade, Francoise Durr, Chrissie (Chris Evert), Martina (Navratilova). Billie put me on the WTA Board of Directors. I played World Team Tennis for the New York Apples. Fred Stolle was our captain, and Billie Jean, Vitas Gerulaitis, and Joanne Russell were on the team. I hung around famous tennis writers Mike Lupica, Frank Deford, Peter Alfano, and Lesley Visser. I soaked up everything. My knees told me that my time in tennis would be short, so I played everywhere I could get into a draw. Maybe everyone thinks that their

In elite company: During her playing days, Mary Carillo (left) shared locker room space with the likes of the legendary Billie Jean King (right) and other '70s tennis stars. GETTY IMAGES

time was the best time, but boy, I truly believe my time was as good as it gets.

When you started your broadcasting career with USA Network in 1980, you were 23. You had no TV experience and were entering a male-dominated field. What were your thoughts and feelings then?

When my knees gave out for the last time in the 1980 Wimbledon first round, I thought I'd go back to coaching for Mr. Hopman, then figure out what to do next. A few weeks after I got home from England, I got a call from Mark Stulburger, who was starting to produce women's tennis for *USA Network*. Mark had heard me call a match from the WTA Finals in Madison Square Garden earlier in the year — a late-night match that I got thrown into after being interviewed by the *MSG Network* announcers. All the big players and celebrities had gone home, so there